Power of Interest

Financial Control Policy

Version: V0.2
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Approval date: 31/07/2026
Review date: 31/07/2028

Purpose and Scope

The purpose of this policy is to establish robust financial controls to protect the assets of Power of Interest (POI) UK, ensure the reliable recording of financial data, and maintain public trust.

This policy applies to all trustees, directors, student coordinators, coaches, and general volunteers handling money, tracking grants, processing online payments, or incurring expenses on behalf of POI UK.

General Financial Governance

- **Financial Records:** All financial transactions must be recorded transparently using an agreed accounting or a secured master ledger spreadsheet. All digital or physical receipts must be retained for at least 7 years.

Banking and Signatory Controls

- **Bank Accounts:** All bank accounts must be held in the official name of the charity. No personal bank accounts may be used to hold charity funds under any circumstances.
- **Dual Authorization (The Four-Eyes Principle):**
  - Any electronic bank transfer or check payment exceeding **£100** requires authorization from two independent bank signatories (e.g., the Treasurer and a designated Trustee), and agreed by a majority of the board
  - No individual can set up and approve the same payment.
- **Online Banking Access:** Login credentials, passwords, and multi-factor authentication (MFA) devices must never be shared among student volunteers or directors.

Income and Revenue Generation

As a debating organisation, income typically originates from tournament registration fees, institutional grants, corporate sponsorships, and individual donations.

- **Online Payments:** Tournament registration and workshop fees must be collected using secure, approved platforms (e.g., Stripe, PayPal, or Eventbrite). These accounts must link directly to the central POI UK bank account.
- **Cash and Cheques (In-Person Tournaments):**
  - Cash handling at tournaments must be strictly limited. Schools should be strongly encouraged to pay via bank transfer.

- Where cash is taken on-site (e.g., tuck shops, printed materials, last-minute entry fees), it must be counted by **two volunteers**, recorded on a cash-count sheet, and deposited into the bank account within **3 working days**.

- **Grant Funding:** Funds received from educational grants or corporate sponsors must be tracked separately to ensure compliance with any specific donor-restricted terms.

Expenditure and Purchasing Limits

To empower student directors while mitigating financial risk, the following spending authority limits are established:

Transaction Value	Required Approval Level
Up to £50	Can be spent by an authorized Student Project Lead (e.g., buying tournament trophies/printing).
£50 to £500	Requires prior written approval (email text suffices) from the Treasurer.
Over £500	Requires formal approval from a majority vote of the Board of Trustees.

- **Invoicing:** All suppliers must provide a valid invoice before payment is disbursed.

Volunteer and Coach Expenses

POI UK relies heavily on university student volunteers traveling to coach or judge at tournaments and other weekly sessions

- **Prior Authorization:** All volunteer expenses must be approved in writing before they are incurred.
- **Valid Proof:** Expense claims will only be reimbursed upon submission of an official POI UK Expense Claim Form accompanied by a valid VAT receipt or proof of transport purchase. Bank statements alone are not acceptable proof.
- **Mileage Allowance:** Travel by personal vehicle will be reimbursed at standard UK government rates (currently **45p per mile** up to 10,000 miles) if pre-approved.

Fraud, Bribery, and Conflicts of Interest

- **Conflict of Interest:** No trustee, director, or volunteer may benefit financially from a purchasing decision made by POI UK. Any potential conflict (e.g., buying tournament venues or merchandise from a company owned by a volunteer's relative) must be declared openly and voted on by non-conflicted trustees.
- **Reporting Financial Abuse:** Any suspicion of financial theft, fraud, or bribery must be reported immediately to the Chair of the Board. If a serious incident occurs involving a loss of charity assets, it must be reported to the Charity Commission as a Serious Incident Report.